THE GACHA FEVER

Internet Gaming Disorder (IGD) Among Southeast Asian Gamers in the Age of In-App Purchases (IAP)

The Overfitters

Abon, Benedict Aldous

Hernandez, Zachary James

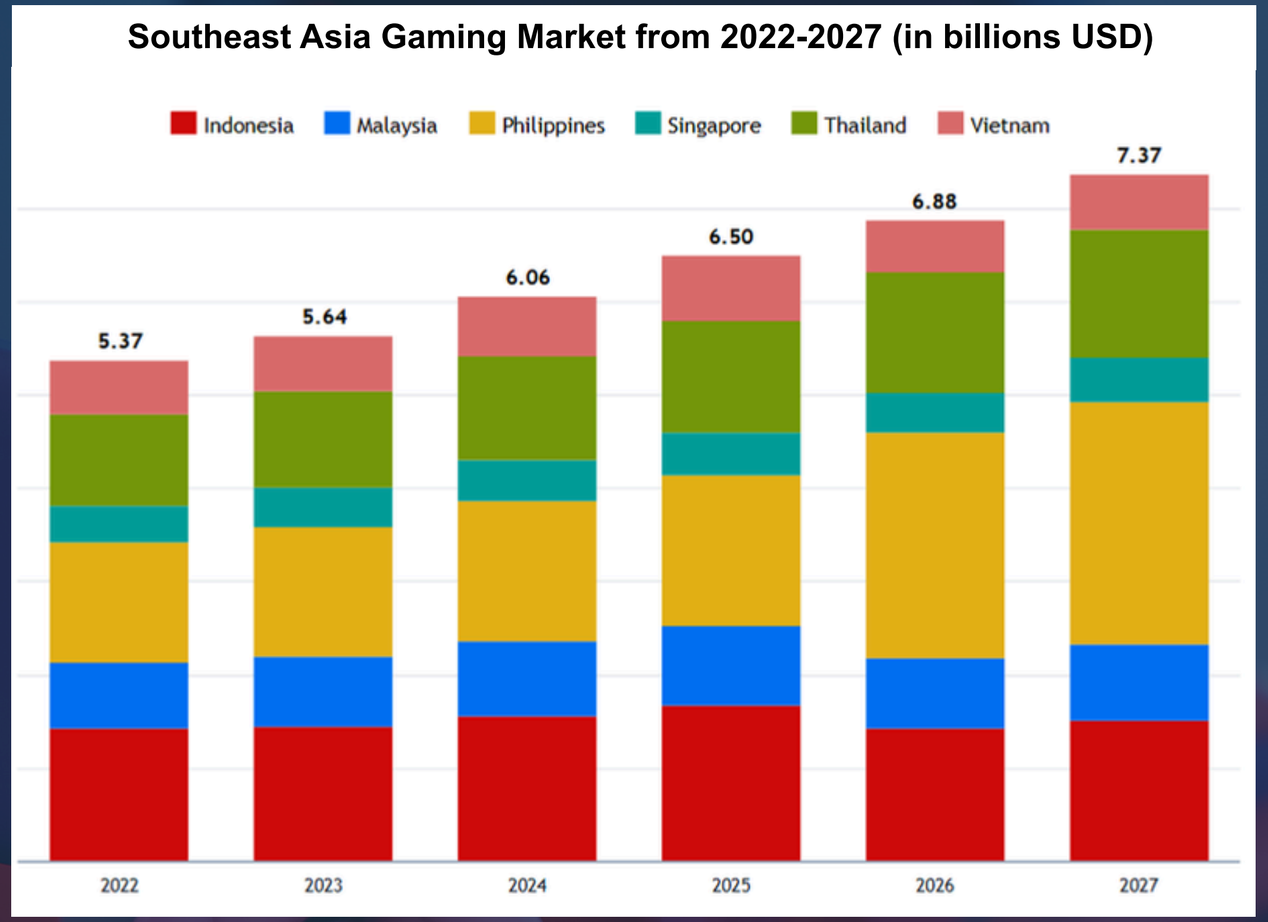
Institution: Technological Institute of the Philippines - Quezon City

3 GOOD HEALTH AND WELL-BEING

The gaming market in SEA is projected to reach

$7.37 BILLION

by 2027. (Allcorrect, 2025)



Indonesia, Malaysia, Philippines, Thailand, Vietnam, and Singapore **prominently define** the video game market revenue of Southeast Asia.

GACHA, IAP, AND LOOTBOX GAMES

MAKE PLAYERS SPEND REAL MONEY.

- These games are the **popular game models** today.
- Players make **micro-transactions** just to **improve gaming experience.**

(Thavamuni et al., 2025).



In-App Purchase (IAP) games



Lootbox Games

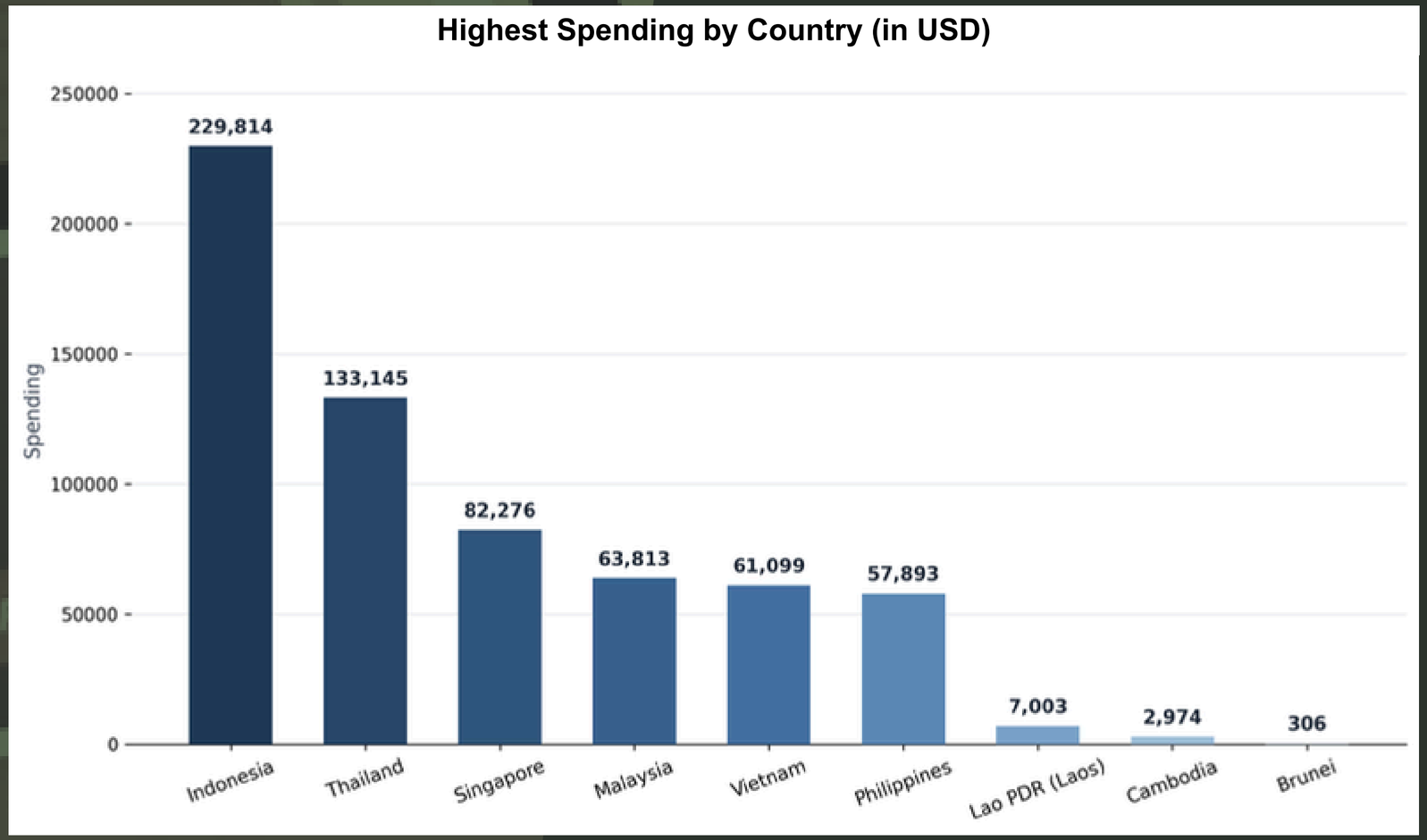


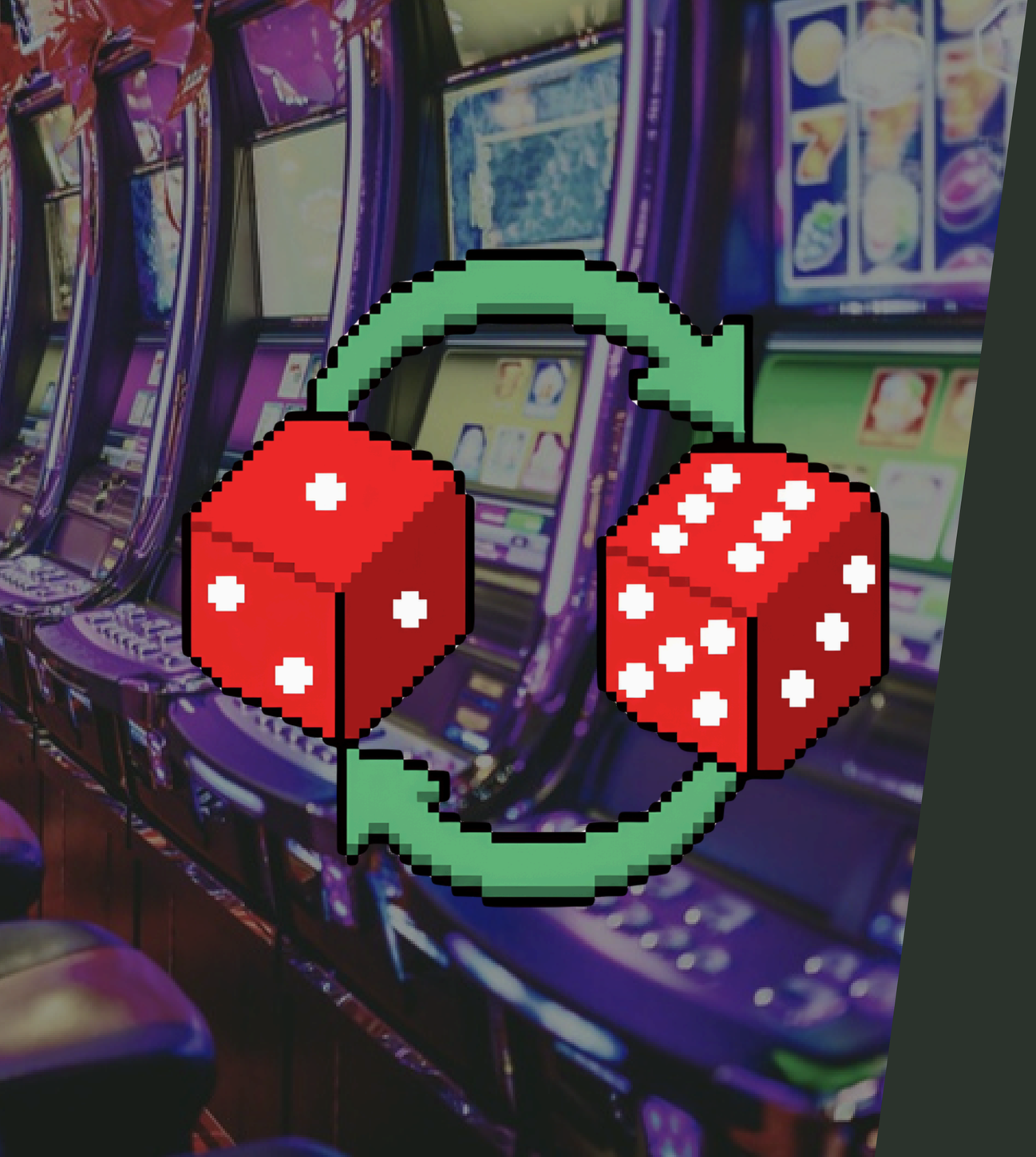
Gacha games

SPENDING HABITS OF SEA GAMERS

Indonesia, Thailand, and Singapore show the highest recorded spending in games among ASEAN countries.

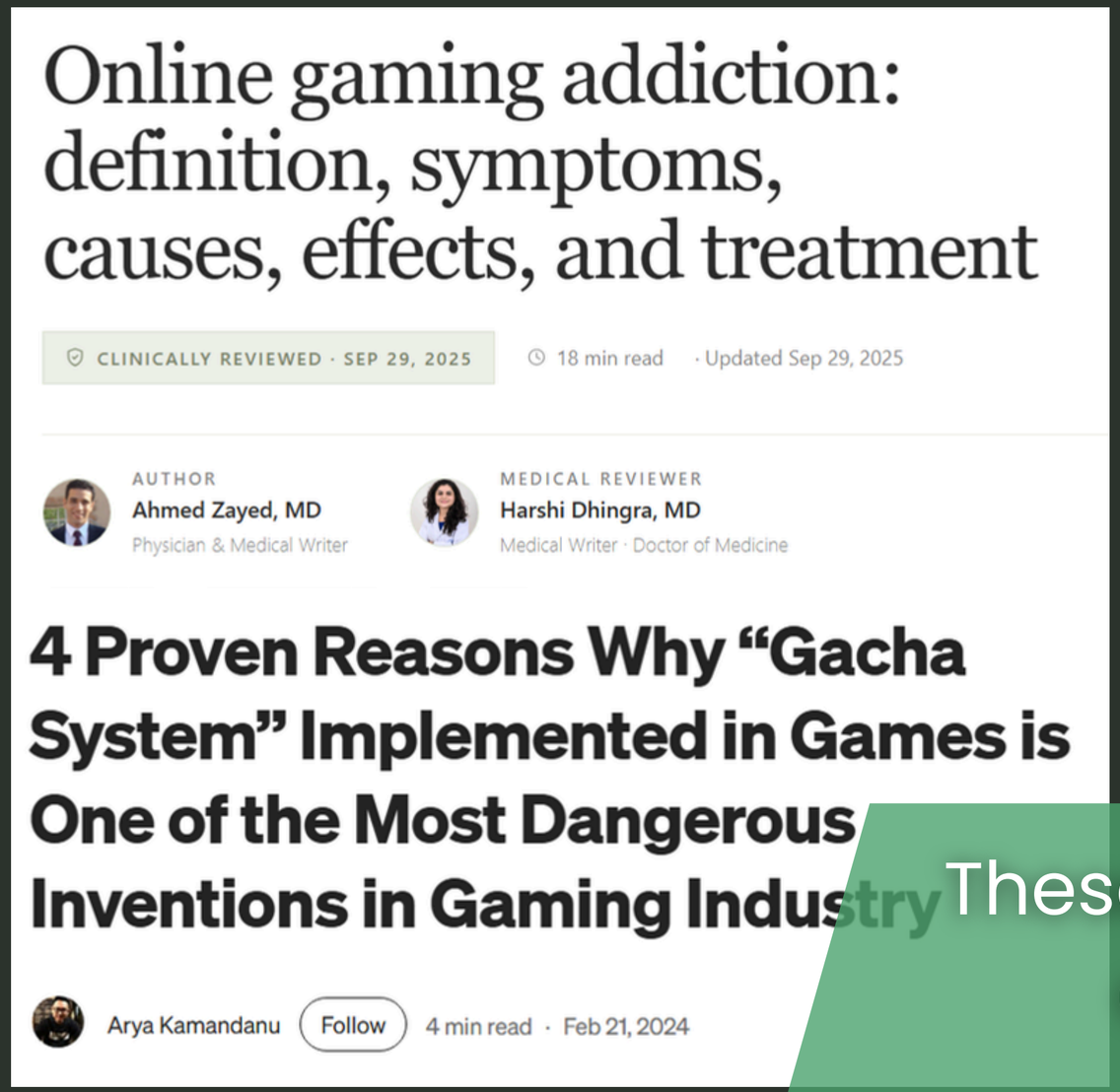
(SDU Metaverse Lab, 2022).





“UNCERTAINTY AND MICROTRANSACTIONS ARE A DEADLY COMBINATION IN VIDEO GAMES.” (Kamandanu, 2024).

- Most IAP games **resembles slot games**, which applies random number generators **(RNGs)**
- Near-misses spark anticipation and encourage another try. (SMBtech, 2025)



Online gaming addiction: definition, symptoms, causes, effects, and treatment

CLINICALLY REVIEWED · SEP 29, 2025 · 18 min read · Updated Sep 29, 2025

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4 Proven Reasons Why "Gacha System" Implemented in Games is One of the Most Dangerous Inventions in Gaming Industry

Arya Kamandanu Follow 4 min read · Feb 21, 2024

THESE GAMES ACTIVATE THE REWARD SYSTEM.

- These games targets the brain's reward system through visual animations and euphoria when **getting something limited or rare.**
- This triggers **dopamine effect**, making players want to experience that feeling longer and eventually drive them to **play continuously.**

These experiences are core **symptoms** of **Internet Gaming Disorder (IGD)** (Zayed & Dhingra, 2023).

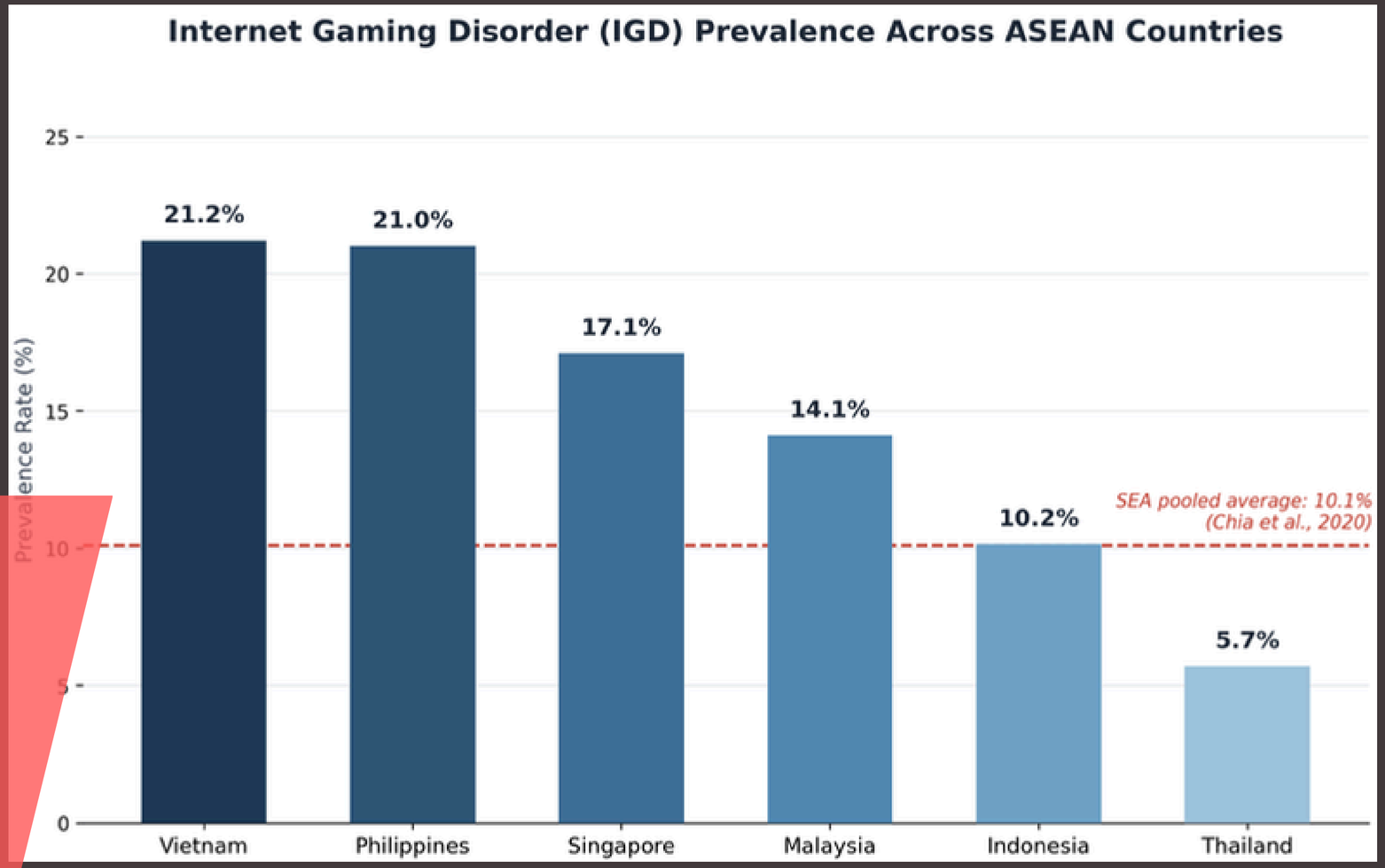
IGD PREVALENCE RISES THROUGHOUT SOUTHEAST ASIA,

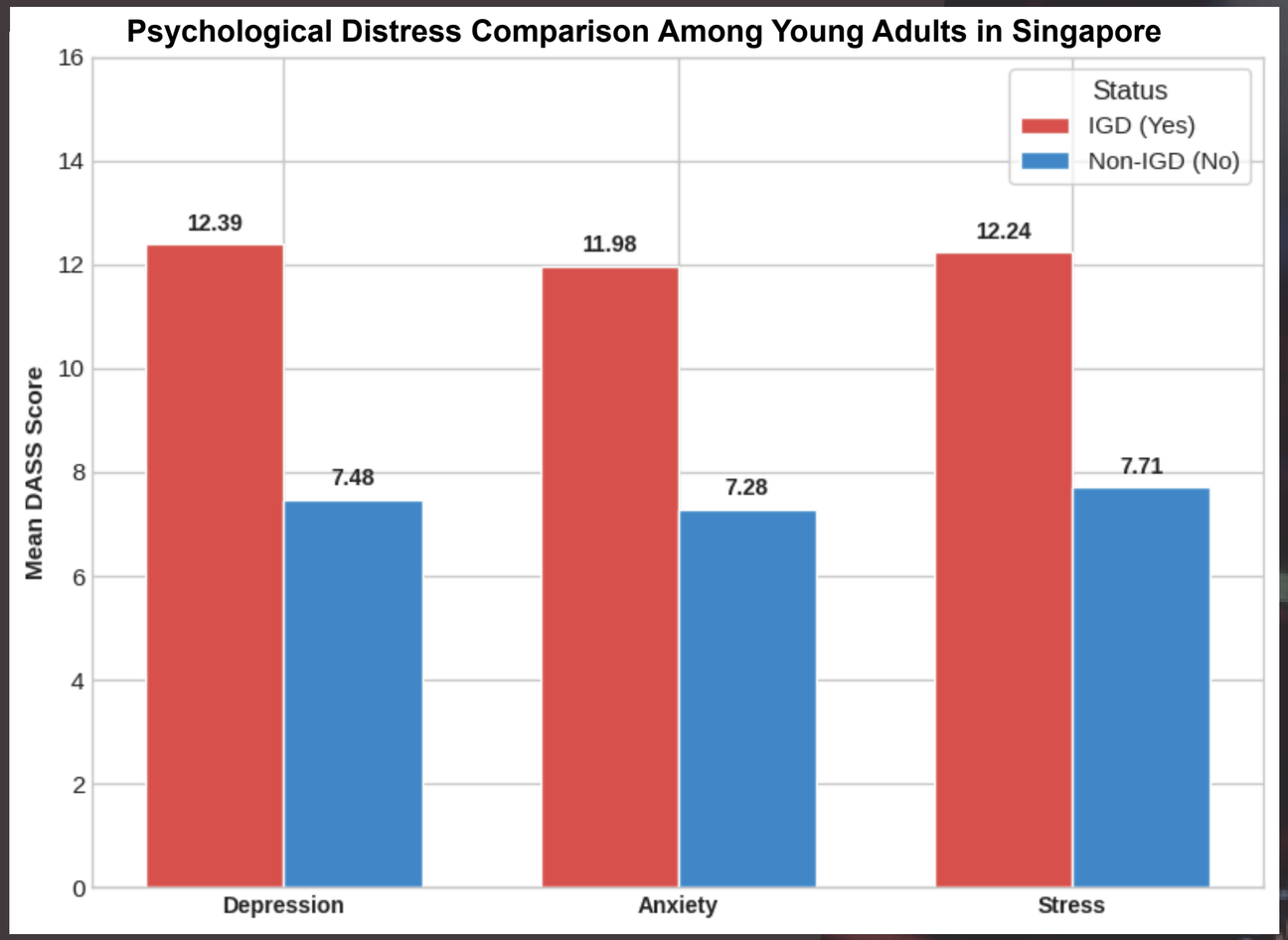
with an **overall** pooled prevalence of

10.1%

(Chia et al., 2020)

Internet Gaming Disorder (IGD) is the behavioural condition that gives patients a compulsive urge to play games at the cost of negatively affecting their lives.





Data: https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC12213995/pdf/11126_2025_Article_10119.pdf

IGD TRIGGERS PSYCHOLOGICAL DISTRESS.

- Distressed adolescents use excessive gaming as **coping mechanism**, but only **provokes more emotional difficulties.**
- Adolescents with IGD **develops or worsen** their depression, anxiety and stress (Chew et al., 2020).

IGD IS EXPERIENCED BY ASEAN COUNTRIES.



PHILIPPINE E-JOURNALS

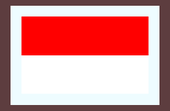
Association of internet gaming disorder to depression, anxiety and stress among Filipino adolescents in selected public high schools in Pasay City

Ma. Kristine Joy Calvario

Discipline: Health

Adolescents in 2 Pasay City high schools had **high prevalence of anxiety.**

(Calvario, 2023).



In Indonesia's Surabaya, some 3,000 children, adolescents treated for mobile gadgets, online gaming addiction

A psychiatrist at Surabaya's Menur Mental Hospital says that those brought to the hospital for their addiction exhibited angry and antisocial behaviours.

A mental hospital in Indonesia's East Java province faces an **epidemic like** growth of **addiction to online gaming in the youth.**

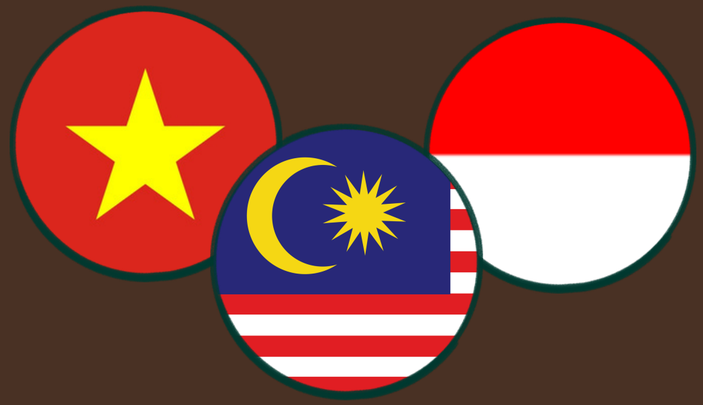
(CNA, 2024).





Since the **COVID-19 Pandemic**, Singaporean therapists and counsellors noted a **30% spike** in gaming addiction, **4 out of 5** of which are **young**, particularlly s**tudents**

(CNA, 2025).



With Southeast Asia being a **primary market for gaming, Vietnam, Malaysia, and Indonesia** followed respective **decrees and acts** for published games, focusing on licensing, distribution, data compliance, and rating systems (Kient, 2024).

BUT, ARE THESE ENOUGH?

ROLL-OUT

Roll-Out is a **behavior-change system** that works across any application with **microtransactions.** It mainly **tracks and predicts** and **intervenes** with **alert pop-ups** in real time when overspending lapses are detected.

MAIN FEATURES

- **Always-on-top Pop-ups**, containing coercive messages that are delivered at risk moments.
- **Just-In-Time Adaptive Intervention (JITAI)** predicts spending by real-time sensing.
- **Personal Dashboard**, visualizing streak history and patterns.
- **Smartwatch Integration**, senses internal state via heart rate sensor and accelerometer



APP WORKFLOW



Inspects spending behavior and internal state on playing session via JITAI digital framework.

Intervene with coercive pop-ups when spending is detected.

Records responses and improve framework real-time.



SDG 3: GOOD HEALTH AND WELL-BEING

Pull-Out is alligned to SDG 3's **Target 3.4** which aims to **promote mental health and well-being**. It aims to help its users **play in moderation** to **maintain a healthy lifestyle** and **avoid the negative mental effects** they may be exposesd to from IGD.

RØ FORCES



Governments
will be the leading actor in implement this as well as advertising it to the public as well as provide mental heal services to users.



App stores
and other websites that allow users to download gacha games can also advertise this application to gacha gamers.



Game Developers
can include reminders for moderation to their users as well as promote responsible expenses with the help of the app



Family Households
can also help by providing support and guidance to family members



ASEAN REGIONAL IN-APP PURCHASE INTERVENTION POLICY FRAMEWORK

Standardize real-time behavioral friction across all mobile and digital games operating within ASEAN member states. This framework aligns with the ASEAN Guidelines on **Consumer Protection in E-Commerce** and emerging regional digital codes, such as **Malaysia's MCMC Content Code** and **Singapore's IMDA player-protection standards.**

- Localization & Regional Trigger Logic
- Mandatory Overlay UI & Localized Messaging
- Compliance & Cross-Border Data Privacy

ROADMAP



1st Year
Research and preparation of necessary resources



2nd Year
Development of the applications, including required features



3rd Year
Coordination with governments and other concerned parties



4th Year
Preparation of facilities and resources for operations



5th Year
Launch of application and further updates

PLAY FOR FUN,





NOT FOR THE PULL.

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